

Passages - The Fall

You have to be methodical when you have no character.

Even in the minutiae of daily life, I needed to be up above.

At every moment of the day, whether I was alone or with other people, I climbed the heights, I lit bonfires up there and heard the joyous acclaim rising up towards me.

Life, its creatures and its gifts came to me and I accepted these tokens of esteem with benevolent pride.

What we like in our friends is fresh death, painful death, our own feelings, in short, ourselves!

That's what men are like, sir: two-faced: they cannot love unless they love themselves.

I felt as though I was partly unlearning what I had never learned and yet knew so well: I mean, how to live.

Someone has to have the last word. Otherwise every point of view would give rise to its opposite and there'd be no end to it all. Power, on the other hand, settles everything.

If a man can't help having slaves, isn't it better for him to call them free men?

I loved women - which amounts to saying that I never loved any one of them.

By not being romantic, I nourished romantic ideas in others, because our women friends have one thing in common

with Bonaparte, which is that they always think they will succeed where others have failed.

It is better to go to bed with a mystery

The act of love is a confession. It cries out, blatantly, with egotism, or vanity is clearly displayed, or else it reveals true generosity.

You are only excused for happiness and success if you generously agree to share them. But if one is to be happy, one should not worry too much about other people - which means that there is no way out. Happy and judged or absolved and miserable.

Of course, I did sometimes pretend to be taking life seriously.

But the frivolity of seriousness itself very quickly became apparent to me and I merely continued to play my role as best I could.

We're going forward, but nothing changes. This is not sailing, but a dream.

What does it matter, after all? Don't lies in the end put us on the path to truth? And don't my stories, true or false, point to the same conclusion? Don't they have the same meaning? So, what does it matter whether they are true or false if, in either case, they signify what I have been and what I am? One can sometimes see more clearly in a person who is lying than in one who is telling the truth. Like light, truth dazzles. Untruth, on the other hand, is a beautiful dusk that enhances everything.

The more I accuse myself, the more I have the right to judge you. Better still I incite

you to judge yourself, which relieves me by that much more

But don't worry. It's too late now, it will always be too late. Thank goodness!